

Berzerka

Players: 3 players / **Time:** 30-75 minutes / **Age:** 13+

(I am sure you can play this with someone younger, but I haven't tested that theory yet. Let me know if you do!)

Theme (Yeahhh, don't think too hard about it. This is just a card game!)

It's time for the 30th Berzerka-lympics! You find yourself standing center stage of the arena. You've been training for this moment your entire life. The only thing that stands in your way is the competition across from you...

Each player takes the role of a Berserker who has made it to the final stage of this grand contest. It will take cunning tactics, back up plans, and maybe a little bit of rage to become the next champion. You are only a few events away from that decision. So, get out there and make a name for yourself!

Game Overview

Berzerka is a compendium¹ trick taking game that takes inspiration from Mizerka and Coiffeur Jass². Over the course of the game, players will be completing various contracts (*will change the rules or objective of the hand*). In Berzerka, the objective of contracts is tied to the number of tricks a player wins in a single hand.

After all players complete the same contract, the number of tricks won will be compared. Whoever ranks highest in that contract will gain Game Points and whoever ranks lowest will lose Game Points. The game ends after all contracts have been completed by all players. The player with the most Game Points wins!

1) *Compendium: A game that has multiple objectives/scoring categories. These objectives are commonly referred to as "contracts". Each player must complete every contract before the game can end. Most importantly, once a player completes a specific contract they cannot attempt to complete that contract again. A very popular example that uses this compendium-style system would be Yahtzee.*

2) *It is ok if you unfamiliar with Mizerka or Coiffeur Jass. Berzerka can be equally enjoyed with or without prior knowledge of either game. However, if you enjoy Berzerka, I would strongly suggest you check out the games that inspired me to design this one!*

Components

- 52 playing cards; four suits, each suit is ranked 1-13
- 1 double-sided 'Overbid Penalty' card
- 1 Card Rank Reminder Card - 1 Trump Suit Reminder Card
- 3 Player Reminder Cards - 3 Player Bid Cards
- 1 Forehand/Hotseat Card
- 13 contract boards (preferably laminated) *see Contract Appendix for more info*
 - *The contract's rules will be on the back of the boards in the final version*
- You will need a writing implement to write on the contract boards

Trick Taking Jargon Explained

Forehand: The player that starts the bidding during the bidding phase.

Declarer: The player that ultimately decides which contract is being played.

Defenders: The players that are playing against the declarer.

In the Hotseat: When the forehand is forced to be the declarer. In traditional games like Coiffeur Jass, you would say "in the barrel".

Trick: In clockwise order, each player plays a card from hand to the table face up.

Lead player: The player who plays the first card to a trick.

Follow player: The players who play a card to the trick after the lead player.

Led suit: The suit (color) of the card played by the lead player.

Trump suit: A suit that is stronger than the other three suits. It does not appear in every contract, but when it does, the suit is determined before the first trick.

Must follow: The lead player may play any card from their hand. Each follow player must play a card that matches led suit, if possible.

Example: Michelle leads with the 5 of Hearts. DJ must follow suit and play a Heart.

Must beat: Follow players must play a card that is stronger than the strongest card in the trick, if possible. (You are berserkers after all, show no mercy!)

Example: Michelle leads with the 5 of Hearts. DJ must follow suit and play a Heart. Additionally, DJ must play a 6 of Hearts or higher, if he has one. DJ has the 3 and 9 of Hearts. Therefore, DJ must play the 9 and cannot play the 3.

Must trump: If a follow player does not have a card in hand that matches the led suit, they must play a card of the trump suit, if possible.

Example (Spades is trump): Michelle leads the 5 of Hearts. DJ must follow and must beat by playing a 6 of Hearts or higher. However, DJ is out of Hearts but has Spades in hand. Therefore, he must play a Spade, of any rank, from his hand.

Off suit: If a follow player does not have a card in hand that matches the led suit and they do not have a card of the trump suit (or there is no trump suit), they may play any card.

Example (Spades is trump): Michelle leads the 5 of Hearts. DJ must follow and must beat by playing a 6 of Hearts or higher. DJ is out of Hearts so he must trump by playing Spades. However, DJ is also out of Spades. Therefore, he can play any card of his choice from the other two suits, Clubs or Diamonds.

*Note: You must always check for the **must follow** rule before checking the **must beat** and **must trump** rules. This applies even if someone plays a card of the led suit that is stronger than your strongest card in that suit.*

Example (Spades is trump): Michelle leads the 5 of Hearts. DJ follows with the 9 of Hearts. Jacob has the 2 of Hearts, 7 of Hearts, and 4 of Spades in hand. Because he still has Hearts in hand he must play one of them. They are all weaker than DJ's 9 of Hearts, so Jacob can play either one. Jacob would not have been able to play the 4 of Spades (trump suit) in this situation because he could still follow the led suit.

Game Setup

- Select and place 5 contract boards near the middle of the table, within easy reach of all players. (Place 3 contracts in a short game, see page 10 for more)

For your first game, it is recommended to use the starting contracts, labeled with a star. There are other mix-n-match contracts you can use in future games.

- Place the deck, player reminder, player bid, trump suit reminder, card rank reminder, overbid penalty cards, and the writing implement near the contract boards.

- The first person to ask "Who starts?", "Who goes first?", or something similar will be the forehand. Give that player the forehand token.

- Each player should pick a player color and write their name (or initials) in the 'Player' box under the matching player color on each contract board.



Gameplay

Berzerka will be played over 15 hands (9 in a short game, see page 10 for more).

A hand will consist of 5 phases in the following order:

- 1) Initial Dealing
- 2) Bidding & Finish Dealing
- 3) Discarding & Drawing
- 4) Trick taking
- 5) End of Hand Scoring

1) Initial Dealing

At the beginning of each hand, the forehand will shuffle the deck and deal 7 cards to each player, face down. Players take their cards into hand, but keep them hidden from the other players. The forehand should place the rest of the deck nearby, facedown.

2) Bidding & Finish Dealing

Starting with the forehand and going clockwise, each player may bid on a contract or pass. **You cannot bid on a contract that you have already completed this game.** At the beginning of the game no contracts have been completed and any player may bid on any contract.

Note: Players are only dealt 7 cards at this time, but the final hand size for the trick taking phase will be 13 cards. This means players are making bids with only (slightly more than) half of their hand. *Berserkers can be filled with blind rage and don't always see clearly when making decisions!* However, there is a situation where players could bid with their entire hand (explained on the next page).

When bidding on a contract you must say the name of the contract and place your bid card next to the contract board. If your contract requires giving **additional information**, such as picking a trump suit or card rank order, you **do not** provide that information at this time.



Example: DJ (Orange) bids by saying "Hidden Strength" and places his bid card next to it.

Players may bid on the same or different contracts as another player. However, a player cannot change their contract choice during this phase. Once you bid on a contract for the hand, it's that contract or bust! In a situation where two or more players want to bid on a contract (same or different), then overbidding occurs.

Overbidding:

The first time any player bids on any contract they do not need to overbid. However, if there are any subsequent bids, those will require overbidding. To overbid, name your contract, place your bid card next to it (*if it is not there already*) and take the overbid penalty card. If this is the first overbid, place the card with the 1 rotated towards the top.

Each time a player overbids another player, they must take the overbid penalty card and rotate it by one number (1 → 2 → 3...), increasing the overbid amount.

If you have already bid on a contract and another player overbids you, your options are to either continue to overbid or pass.

The penalty for overbidding is the number of discards the declarer will add to their discarded amount (see Discarding & Drawing on page 7 for more).



Example:

Torselli (White) overbids DJ's bid by saying "Berzerka" and places his bid card. This is the first overbid, so Torselli takes the overbid penalty card and rotates the '1' towards the top. Jacob (Blue) passes. At this point, DJ can either overbid Torselli by taking the overbid penalty card and rotating it towards the '2' or Pass. DJ decides to pass on Hidden Strength.

Passing:

If a player passes, they will no longer participate in bidding this hand (*hard pass*). Once all but one player passes, that remaining player becomes the declarer. **Only the declarer's contract is played! All other contract bids that were made are ignored.** If any other player bid on a contract, they must take back their placed bid card now. Then, proceed to i) under Finish Dealing.

What happens if all players pass? The Forehand is "put in the hotseat"!

It is possible that all three players pass in a row (no one places a bid while holding half their hand). **In this situation, the forehand is put in the hotseat, becomes the declarer, and must bid on a contract.** However, this bid comes after players are dealt the rest of their hand. Proceed to ii) under Finish Dealing.

Finish Dealing:

i) If players reached this step because a half hand bid was made:

- Before the forehand finishes dealing, the declarer must mark the 'Half Bid' section for the matching contract to show a half hand bid was made.
- Then, if the contract requires **additional information** (pick trump, card rank order, etc.) the declarer must provide that now.

★	BERZERKA	NAME	DJ	Torselli	Jacob
		HALF BID	X		
		Objective: Win as many tricks as possible			
		Card Ranking: Trump Suit:			

Example: DJ is the declarer after bidding Berzerka with half of his hand. He marks the 'Half Bid' section on that contract. Then, this contract requires additional info (pick a trump suit), so he announces to the table that Diamonds will be trump.

After the above steps are completed, the forehand should finish dealing the hand by giving each player 6 more cards. Players will now have 13 cards and 13 cards will be left undealt. Place the 13 undealt cards face down, nearby. These undealt cards will be referred to as the draw pile and will be used in the next phase.

ii) If players reached this step because the forehand was in the hotseat:

- The forehand finishes dealing the hand by giving each player 6 more cards. Players will now have 13 cards and 13 cards will be left undealt. Place the 13 undealt cards face down, nearby. These undealt cards will be referred to as the draw pile and will be used in the next phase.
- The declarer (which is the forehand) must bid on a contract by placing their bid card next to that contract.

Do not mark the 'Half Bid' section as a half hand bid was not made.

- Then, if the contract requires additional info (pick trump, card rank order, etc.) the declarer must provide that now.

Example: All three players passed. This puts DJ, the forehand, in the hotseat. After being dealt the rest of his hand, he bids Berzerka and announces Clubs as trump. He places his bid card next to the contract and does not mark the 'Half Bid' section.

3) Discarding & Drawing

Players will now have the opportunity to discard cards from their hand and draw back up from the draw pile (*the 13 undealt cards*).

i) If players reached this step because a half hand bid was made:

The declarer starts this phase, making the declarer the first person to interact with the discard/draw steps.

ii) If players reached this step because the forehand was in the hotseat:

The player to the left of the declarer starts this phase, making the declarer the last person to interact with the discard/draw steps.

No matter who starts this phase, the 2 steps below are the same for all players and must be done in this exact order:

- 1) Discard any number of cards in hand, face down. This can include 0.**
 - Discards should be placed off to the side. They will not be used for the rest of this hand. Be careful not to confuse them with the draw pile.*

- b. Players may only discard cards equal to or less than the remaining number of cards in the draw pile (e.g. if there are 8 cards left in the draw pile, you may only discard 0-8 cards)

2) Draw an equal number of cards from the draw pile.

- a. E.g. if you discarded 2 cards, you must draw 2 cards from the draw pile.

Repeat steps 1 and 2 above, with the next player in clockwise order, until:

- All players have had a chance to discard and draw
- The draw pile is empty

It is possible not everyone gets a chance to discard and draw. This can happen if the first or second player discards and draws enough cards to empty the draw pile. On the flip side, it is possible that there will be cards left in the draw pile. In that case, leave them facedown for the rest of the round. They will not be used this hand.

If you are the declarer, you must record the number of cards you discarded (along with any overbid penalty) by writing that number in the matching contract box. The other players do not record their discard amounts!

★	BERZERKA	NAME	DJ
Objective: Win as many tricks as possible		HALF BID	X
Card Ranking:	Trump Suit:	DISCARD	4
Normal	Yes		
Additional Information Needed: Choose a trump suit			

Example:

DJ discards 3 cards in hand and draws 3 cards from the draw pile. He also has an overbid penalty of 1. He bid on the Berzerka contract. He must write the number 4 in the 'Discard' section of that contract.

Increasing A Contract's Value:

After all players discard and draw and/or the draw pile is emptied, the declarer must decide if they want to increase the contract value for themselves or not.

Important: This increase only applies to the declarer, not the other players!

If the declarer wants to increase the contract value:

- Decide the new value to increase it to, maximum of +3.
- Write the new value in the 'Value' section matching their player color.

★	SEEING RED	NAME	DJ	Torselli	Jacob
Objective: Win as many tricks as possible		HALF BID	X		
Card Ranking:	Trump Suit:	DISCARD	6		
Normal	Red (Hearts)				
Additional Information Needed: None					
		TRICKS			
2	3	4	5		
VALUE			2		
		POINTS			

Example:

Torselli bid Seeing Red. After discarding and drawing, he decided he wanted to increase the contract value for himself by 1. So, he writes the number 3 (base value+1) in his 'Value' section.

If the declarer does not want to increase the contract value:

- Write the lowest value in the 'Value' section matching their player color.

★	SEEING RED	NAME	DJ	Torselli	Jacob
Objective: Win as many tricks as possible		HALF BID		X	
Card Ranking:	Trump Suit:	DISCARD		6	
Normal	Red (Hearts)				
Additional Information Needed: None					
		TRICKS			
2	3	4	5		
VALUE			2		
		POINTS			

Example:

Torselli bid Seeing Red. After discarding and drawing, he decided he did not want to increase the contract value for himself. So, he writes the number 2 (base value for Seeing Red) in his 'Value' section.

Designer Note: Look at this increase as a wager. How confident are you that you will do well enough to rank first in this contract? The more confident you are, the higher you should increase the contract value. Thematically, this is how much you (a Berserker) are berserking, or raging out, during your event.

After increasing the value or not, proceed to the Trick Taking phase.

4) Trick Taking

- This is a **must follow, must beat, must trump** trick taker (refer to 'Trick Taking Jargon Explained' on page 2 for a reminder of what all this means).
- The declarer will always be the lead player for the first trick. The winner of the current trick will be the lead player for the next trick.
- When a player wins a trick, they must collect all cards and place them in a facedown pile in front of themselves. If a player wins multiple tricks, make sure to keep the piles separate so all players can easily tell how many tricks someone has won throughout the hand.

*Clubs is trump for all examples

Trick Example 1) DJ leads with the 8 of Clubs. Torselli follows and beats with the 10 of Clubs. Jacob follows and beats with the 13 of Clubs. Jacob wins and leads the next trick.

Trick Example 2) Jacob leads with the 7 of Hearts. DJ does not have Hearts and must trump. He trumps with the 1 of Clubs. Torselli cannot beat the 1 of Clubs, but can still follow lead. He follows with the 3 of Hearts. DJ wins and leads the next trick.

Trick Example 3) DJ leads with the 12 of Clubs. Torselli cannot beat, but can still follow. He follows with the 9 of Clubs. Jacob is out of Clubs, which is trump, so he cannot beat and cannot trump. Therefore, he can play anything. He plays the 5 of Diamonds. DJ wins and leads the next trick.

After all 13 tricks have been played proceed to End of Hand Scoring.

Only the declarer's number of tricks won will be calculated for scoring! The other players are trying to win (or lose) tricks to have the declarer perform poorly during their contract, but ultimately, only the number of tricks the declarer wins will count for scoring in that hand. The declarer should write the number of tricks they won in the 'Tricks' box for the contract they just completed.

★ BERZERKA		NAME	DJ
Objective: Win as many tricks as possible		HALF BID	X
Card Ranking:	Trump Suit:	DISCARD	3
Normal	Yes	TRICKS	8
Additional Information Needed: Choose a trump suit		POINTS	
VALUE	1 2 3 4		
4			

Torselli and Jacob do not write anything down for this hand.

If an entire row is complete (*meaning all players have completed that same contract at some point throughout the game*) it is time to hand out game points. **Game points are the actual score to the game.**

- The player that did the best at meeting the objective of the contract ranks highest and will gain game points equal to their contract value.
- The player that did the worst ranks lowest in that contract will lose game points equal to their contract value.
- The middle player neither gains nor loses game points.

For the majority of contracts, the objective is to win the most tricks. But there are some that have different objectives. Please refer to the Contract Appendix for each contract's objective.

★ BERZERKA				NAME	DJ	Torselli	Jacob
Objective: Win as many tricks as possible							
Card Ranking:		Trump Suit:					
Normal		Yes					
Additional Information Needed: Choose a trump suit							
1 / 2 / 3 / 4				TRICKS	8	2	6
VALUE	4	1	2	POINTS	4	-1	0

Berzerka Contract Example:
DJ won 8 tricks, Torselli won 2, and Jacob won 6. The contract value is 4 for DJ, 1 for Torselli, and 2 for Jacob. The objective for Berzerka is to win as many tricks as possible. In this game, DJ ranks highest, Torselli lowest, and Jacob middle.

DJ gains 4 game points
Torselli loses 1 game point
Jacob gains/loses 0 game points

- If both players bid with half their hand, then the player with the lowest number written in the 'Discard' section is ranked higher.
- If still tied, the player who completed the contract first is ranked higher.

Designer Note: If you find it difficult to remember who completed a contract first, I recommend writing a small 1/2/3 in the contract box next to the 'Tricks' to show if you were 1st/2nd/3rd to complete the contract.

If there are any contracts left, proceed to the next hand by performing the following steps in order:

- 1) Return the declarer's bid card to them.
- 2) Return the overbid penalty card, if necessary.
- 3) Pass the forehand token clockwise **until it reaches a player that has not completed all of their contracts.**

Important: If the new forehand has already completed all of their contracts, they **can no longer be forehand or declarer**. This means they cannot participate in the Bidding phase and must permanently pass when it is their turn to bid. **However, they participate in every other phase of the game as normal.**

- 4) The new forehand should collect all playing cards and shuffle them together.
5) Repeat the main 5 phases of the game (*starts on page 3*).

If all contracts are completed (9/15 hands played), proceed to End of Game.

After all contracts are completed, each player should add (or subtract) all of their game points across all contracts. It is possible to have a negative score. The player with the highest positive score wins.

If there is a tie, the player who bid with half their hand the most wins.

If still tied, the player with the least total discards across all contracts wins.

If still tied, the player that completed all of their contracts first wins!

To play a short game, players should only select 3 contracts instead of 5 contracts. This will make the game 9 hands long instead of 15. If you are using the starter contracts it is recommended to use Berzerka, Hold Steady, and Bottle It Up. Of course, you may use any of the contracts you'd like!

The base game, by nature, is designed to be rather cutthroat and includes some push your luck elements. If players are enjoying the compendium nature of the game, but would prefer a slightly friendlier and less push your luck-y game, you may implement either of the following variants. All base game rules are exactly the same, unless stated in the variant.

Forehand ‘In The Hotseat’ Is First To Discard/Draw:

- If the forehand is in the hotseat, they start the Discarding & Drawing phase, instead of being last

Less Mizerka Variant:

- Skip the half hand part of dealing/bidding (start with all 13 cards in hand)
- If all players pass, the forehand is still in the hotseat
- First tiebreaker is now ‘Discard’ amounts
- Declarer always starts the Discarding & Drawing phase

Credits

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